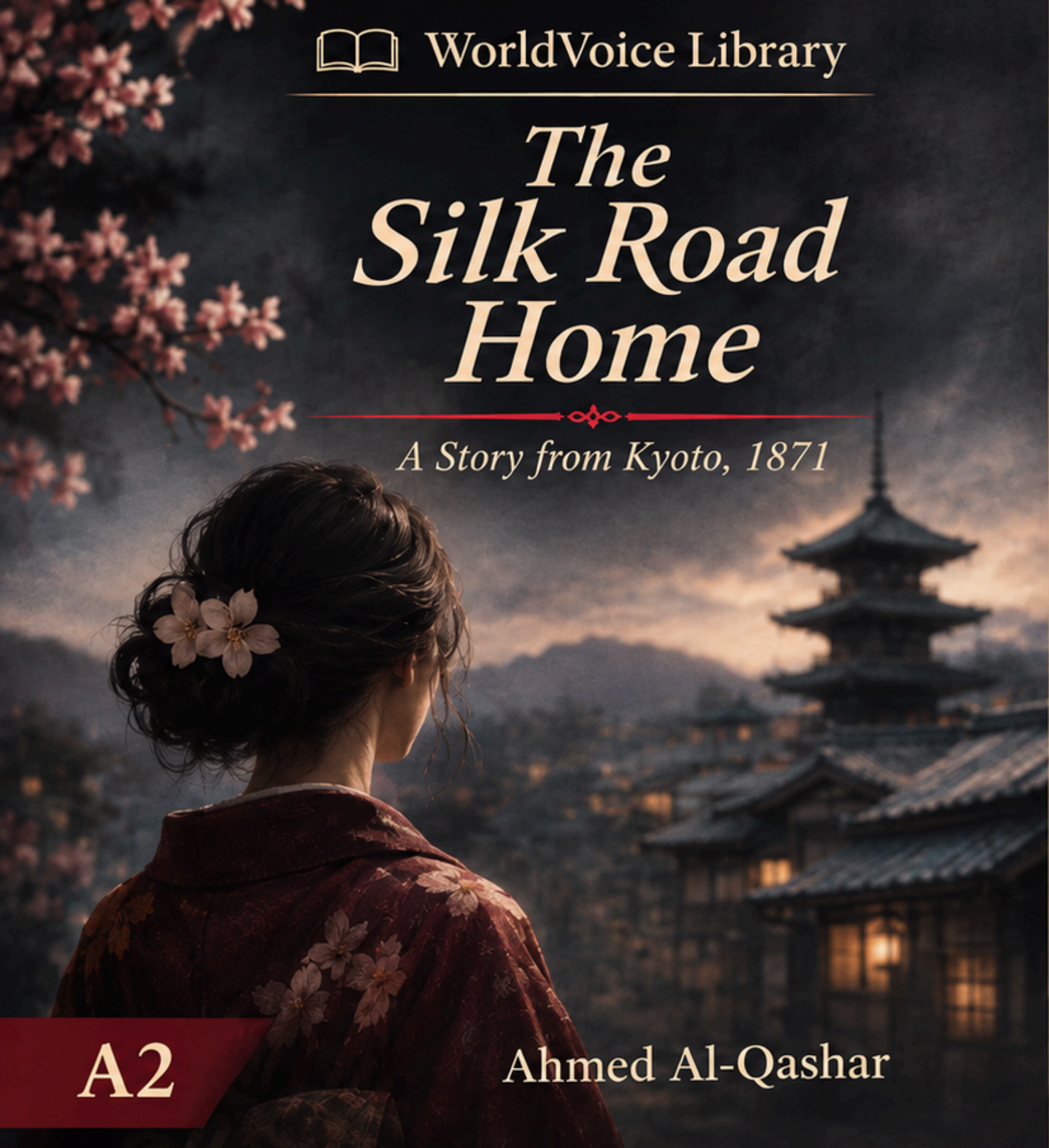

WorldVoice Library
The Silk Road Home
A Story from Kyoto, 1871
A2
Ahmed Al-Qashar

WORLDVOICE LIBRARY

The Silk Road Home

A Story from Kyoto, 1871

Written by
Ahmed Al-Qashar

ENGLISH GRADED READERS
A2 · Elementary

An original WorldVoice Library novel · Editorial review edition

Publication & Rights

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WorldVoice Library — English Graded Readers, A2.

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This is an original work of fiction created for WorldVoice Library. The characters and story events are fictional.

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Read · Learn · Explore

Story Introduction

A missing delivery. A blue stitch. A family's future.

Kyoto, 1871. Aiko helps her parents make silk in a small family workshop. When an important buyer says that their cloth is missing, her father may lose the old loom. But Aiko remembers the special blue stitches hidden in every roll. With help from her friends, she follows a trail of carts, letters, and records to find out what really happened.

The journey takes her far from the family workshop. As she searches for the truth, Aiko must decide when to speak and whom to trust.

Before You Read

1. Look at the cover. What can you learn about Kyoto and the young woman?
2. Why are written records useful when people buy and sell goods?
3. Have you ever tried to solve a problem with help from a friend?

Characters

The people you will meet in the story



Aiko
A seventeen-year-old weaver who tries to save her family's workshop.



Daichi
Aiko's father, who makes beautiful silk and worries about losing the loom.



Yumi
Aiko's mother, who knows the secret blue stitch used on their cloth.



Ren
A friend of Aiko who carries silk to the shops by cart.



Emi
A young worker who risks her job to tell Aiko what she saw.

Merchant Kondo — The silk buyer who believes his clerk's false report.

Sato — Kondo's clerk, who hides the true story of the delivery.

Mrs. Mori — A market shopkeeper who keeps careful written records.

Chiyo — A delivery worker who has another important note.

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The Silk Road Home · English A2

Read all five chapters before completing the activities at the back of the book.

CHAPTER 1

The Blue Thread

In the spring of 1871, the streets of Kyoto were full of rain. Water ran down the stone steps and made little rivers beside the wooden houses. Inside a small workshop, seventeen-year-old Aiko sat at a loom. She moved her hands slowly, from left to right. A long piece of green silk grew in front of her. In the morning light, it looked like a quiet river.

Aiko's family made silk in the western part of the city. They did not have a large shop or many workers. They had two looms, a wooden table, and an old chest for their best cloth. Her father, Daichi, had learned to weave from his father. Her mother, Yumi, prepared the thread and checked every finished piece. Aiko helped them both. The family was not rich, but their work was good.



"Do not pull the thread so hard," Yumi said. "Good silk needs time."

"I know, Mother." Aiko smiled. "You said that yesterday."

"Then you are lucky. I can say it again tomorrow."

They laughed. From the next room came the sound of Daichi counting the finished rolls of cloth. On every roll, Yumi had made a small blue mark with three stitches. The mark looked like a mountain over a line of water. It was the family sign. Other makers used stamps, but Yumi said that a stitched mark could not fall off in the rain.

That afternoon, a boy named Ren arrived with a letter. Ren worked for his uncle, who delivered goods between Kyoto and the villages to the west. He was eighteen, tall and kind, and often came to the workshop with parcels. Today he was not smiling.

"A messenger left this at our shop," he said. "It is from Merchant Kondo."

Daichi opened the letter at once. He read it once, and then a second time. His face changed. Aiko had never seen him look so worried.

"What does it say?" Yumi asked.

"Kondo says that half our silk did not arrive," Daichi answered. "He says the other half was damaged. He wants his advance money back."

Aiko put down her work. "But we sent twenty-four rolls. I helped carry them to Ren's cart."

"I know," said Daichi. "And they were dry and clean."

The family had made twenty-four fine rolls for Kondo's spring order. He agreed to pay four silver coins for each roll. He paid twenty-four coins in advance, so he still owed the family seventy-two. That money would buy food, thread, and wood for the coming months.

"If we do not return the advance in fourteen days," Daichi said quietly, "he will take our large loom. It is written in the agreement."

For a moment, nobody spoke. The large loom was the heart of the workshop. Without it, they could not finish important orders. Aiko

looked at its smooth wooden frame. She remembered her grandfather sitting beside it and teaching her the first simple pattern.

Ren stepped closer. "I drove the cart to Kondo's store myself. His clerk counted the rolls."

"Did you get a paper?" asked Aiko.

Ren looked down. "The clerk told me he would send a receipt later. I was in a hurry. I did not wait."

"Then we must find the truth," Aiko said.

Daichi folded the letter. "This is a problem for adults. You have work here."

Aiko touched the blue stitches on the new roll in front of her. "The silk belongs to all of us," she said. "The problem belongs to all of us too."

Outside, the rain stopped. A pale line of sunlight touched the wet street. Aiko did not know it yet, but the small blue mark would lead her far from the safe room where she had spent most of her life.

The next morning, Aiko walked with her father to Kondo's store. The building stood on a busy street near the market. It had a wide front room, high shelves, and a large sign above the door. Men carried boxes across the floor. Customers asked questions about cloth, prices, and delivery dates. Nobody paid attention to Aiko's simple blue coat.

Merchant Kondo stood behind a desk. His hair was turning grey, and he wore a dark jacket. Beside him sat his clerk, Sato, a thin man with careful handwriting. A thick book of accounts lay open between them.

"We have come about the letter," Daichi said.

Kondo looked tired. "I am sorry, Daichi. My clerk has checked the delivery. Only twelve rolls arrived in a condition I could sell. I cannot pay for goods that I did not receive."

"All twenty-four rolls were good," Daichi answered. "My wife checked them before we sent them."

Sato turned a page. "The record is clear. Twelve rolls were lost on the road. The other twelve were wet. Their colour changed. They could not be sold."

Ren was waiting outside with the cart. Aiko had asked him to come. Now she opened the shop door and called him in.

"Did the cart fall into a river?" she asked.

"No," said Ren. "It did not even rain that day. I covered the cloth with a clean sheet."

Sato raised his eyebrows. "Young people often forget small things."

"I remember the road," Ren replied. "I remember the morning. I remember your hands counting the twenty-four rolls at the back door."

"We receive many carts," Sato said. "You may be thinking of another day."

Aiko looked at the open book. The writing was small, but she could read some numbers. There was a line for their order and a number twelve beside it. Another line was covered by Sato's hand.

"May I see the delivery page?" she asked.

Sato closed the book. "Accounts are private."

Kondo moved his hand over the desk. "Please understand. I do not want to take your loom. But I gave you money for an order I cannot sell. The agreement gives me a right to get it back."

Daichi took a long breath. "Then allow me time to find the rolls."

"Fourteen days," Kondo said. "That is all I can offer."

They left the store in silence. In the street, Aiko saw fine red cloth in another shop window. People were buying and selling as if nothing important had happened. She wanted to shout that her family's future was in danger. Instead she asked one question.

"Father, do you keep a second record of every order?"

"I keep dates and prices," Daichi said. "But I do not write the names of the men who carry the goods."

"That must change," Aiko replied.

Daichi gave a sad smile. "You sound like a business teacher."

"I sound like someone who wants our loom to stay at home."

Near the market gate, Ren suddenly stopped. "There is something else. On the day of the delivery, a small cart left Kondo's back door. It went west. I saw blue cloth over the boxes."

"Why did you not say that inside?" Aiko asked.

"I did not think it mattered. Many carts leave that shop."

Aiko looked toward the hills beyond Kyoto. If their missing silk had not stayed in Kondo's store, perhaps it had gone somewhere else. The road west was long, but it had shops and villages all along it.

"We need to find that cart," she said.

Daichi shook his head. "You cannot follow every cart in Kyoto."

"Then we start with one thing," Aiko said. "The blue cloth on its boxes."

When she went home, she opened her grandfather's old wooden chest. Beneath patterns and pieces of thread was a little paper map of the roads west of the city. Her grandfather had drawn it many years before. Across the top, in faded ink, he had written: The road that brings silk home.

CHAPTER 2

The Girl at the Gate

On the third day, Aiko returned to the market with Ren. They did not enter Kondo's store. Instead, they waited near the western gate, where carts passed between the city and the villages. Men carried firewood, vegetables, paper, and cloth. There were more carts than Aiko had expected. Every wheel made a different sound on the stones.

"How will we find one cart?" Ren asked.



"We can begin by asking," Aiko said.

At the gate stood a woman who sold hot rice and tea. She knew many drivers because they stopped at her stall. Aiko bought two small cakes, then described the cart with the blue cover. The woman thought for a moment.

"There was one like that," she said. "It had a broken lamp on its left side. A young girl rode beside the driver."

"Do you know the girl?" asked Ren.

"Her name is Emi. She works at the house of a cloth dealer outside the city. She often comes to buy paper."

"Where is that house?" Aiko asked.

The woman pointed to the west. "Follow the river until you reach a stone bridge. The house is near a field of small trees. But be careful. The dealer does not like questions."

They thanked her. Ren needed to help his uncle with deliveries that afternoon, so Aiko went back to the workshop. Her mother was sitting by the loom. She was trying to repair a narrow line of green silk. The thread had become caught in the frame.

"I went to the western gate," Aiko said.

Yumi looked up. "Your father told me. He is worried about you."

"I was with Ren. We found a name: Emi."

Yumi listened without speaking. When Aiko finished, her mother put the green silk aside. "There is something you should know about Kondo," she said. "Years ago, he helped your grandfather. He was a fair man then. People change, but not always in the way we think."

"Do you think he is lying?"

"I do not know. That is why we need evidence, not anger."

Aiko looked at her mother's hands. They were red from years of work. She did not want to ask Yumi for more, but she had one last question. "Can you show me exactly how you made the blue sign?"

Yumi took a small needle. She made three blue stitches on a piece of white cloth: two little points and a line underneath. "The first stitch is short. The second is longer. The third goes under both. Your grandfather used to call it a mountain with a river at its feet."

"Could another workshop use the same mark?"

"Not by accident," Yumi said. "The last stitch turns inside the cloth. You cannot see that from the front."

The next day, Aiko met Ren at first light. This time Daichi gave them permission to visit the dealer's house, but only until midday. He put a little bag of food in Aiko's hands and spoke to Ren with great care.

"Bring her home safely. If anyone is angry, leave. A loom is not worth a person."

They walked west beside the river. The city slowly disappeared behind them. They passed quiet fields, low hills, and a narrow bridge. On the other side, a girl with a bundle of paper was walking toward a house with a dark roof.

"Emi?" Aiko called.

The girl turned. She had a quick face and a small cut on one finger. "Who wants to know?"

"My name is Aiko. I make silk in Kyoto. I need to ask you about a cart."

Emi looked toward the house. Her face changed. "Please do not speak so loudly," she whispered. "If my master hears you, I will lose my place."

Aiko lowered her voice. "We only want the truth."

Emi looked at the blue thread tied around Aiko's wrist. "I have seen that colour before," she said. "And I think you have come a long way for something important."

Emi led Aiko and Ren behind the cloth dealer's house. A path ran between a vegetable garden and a wall of rough stone. From the road, nobody could see them. Emi kept looking over her shoulder.

"I help with cooking and cleaning," she said. "Sometimes I carry small parcels to the market. I am not part of the business."

"We heard that you rode on a cart with a blue cover," Aiko said. "Was that two weeks ago?"

"Yes. A man from Kondo's store sent us some boxes. He said they held new cloth for sale."

"Do you know his name?" asked Ren.

"Sato. He writes the letters. I saw him speaking to our master at the gate."

Aiko felt her heart beat faster. "Do you know what was inside the boxes?"

Emi nodded. "Silk. Green silk, mostly. Very fine. Our master wanted it placed in the dry room. Then he told us to remove the old paper around the rolls."

"Why?" Aiko asked.

"He said the paper was dirty. But it looked clean to me."

Ren stepped forward. "Do you still have any of it?"

"I do not know. We burn old paper every week."

Aiko had a small piece of green silk in her bag. It was a sample from her family's work. She showed it to Emi. "Was the silk like this?"

Emi touched the cloth with one finger. "Yes. The same colour. But the rolls had a little blue mark at the edge."

"A mountain over water?" Aiko asked.

"Yes! How did you know?"

"My mother made that mark."

For a moment, the three young people stood without speaking. Aiko had hoped to find a clue. Now she was almost certain that the missing

rolls had reached this house. But a girl's word against Sato's book might not be enough.

"Can you show us one roll?" Ren asked.

Emi shook her head. "The dry room is locked. My master carries the key. If I open it, I will lose my work. My family needs the money I send home."

"Then we will not ask you to do that," Aiko said. "Thank you for telling us what you know."

A voice came from the other side of the wall. "Emi! Where are you?"

Emi became pale. "I must go. Please leave by the river path."

She hurried away. Aiko and Ren walked behind the wall until they could see the bridge again. Aiko was disappointed. The truth seemed close, yet it stood behind a locked door.

At the bridge, an old man sat beside a basket of tools. He was repairing the wooden handle of a cart. Ren knew him from his uncle's deliveries. His name was Mr. Ito, and he carried goods through the hills. When he saw Ren, he lifted his hand.

"You have come far from the city today," he said.

"We are looking for some silk," Ren replied.

Mr. Ito smiled. "Every road around here carries silk. You must tell me more."

Aiko described the green rolls and the blue mark. Mr. Ito looked toward the dealer's house. "Last week I carried green silk from that house to a second market," he said. "The paper around it was new. On the paper were the words Spring Willow."

"Where is this second market?" Aiko asked.

"In the town beyond the hills. It is a long walk."

"Do you remember the shop?"

"A shop called the Three Pines. I delivered sixteen rolls there. The owner paid the seller's man at once."

"Sixteen?" Aiko repeated. "Not twelve?"

"Sixteen. I helped count them."

They thanked the old man. Walking home, Ren tried to make sense of it. "If Kondo says twelve were lost, and Mr. Ito carried sixteen, perhaps there are two different orders."

"Perhaps," Aiko said. "But the blue mark and the green cloth are ours. I want to see the paper from the Three Pines."

That evening, Aiko drew three things on her grandfather's map: Kondo's store, the house beyond the bridge, and the Three Pines market. A line joined them. She looked at the line until it felt less like a road and more like a question.

CHAPTER 3

A Journey in the Rain

Five days remained before Kondo could take the family loom. Daichi had gone to two friends to ask for a loan, but neither had enough money. Yumi was still weaving. Aiko knew that every hour mattered.

At sunrise, she and Ren left Kyoto for the Three Pines market. This time her father went with them. He did not want Aiko and Ren to travel alone through the hills. They brought rice, water, and a small piece of the family's green silk.



The road climbed between trees. Birds sang above them, and clouds moved slowly across the sky. In one village, a woman was washing cloth beside a stream. In another, children ran after a cart. Aiko had spent her life near the workshop. She had never seen how many people worked along the road that carried their silk.

"Grandfather called this the road that brings silk home," she said.

Daichi nodded. "When he was young, he walked it often. He sold cloth in the villages and came back with thread, food, and stories."

"Why did we stop using it?"

"Large merchants came to the city," Daichi said. "They bought more cloth at one time. It seemed easier to sell to one man than to travel every week."

"But if one man refuses to pay, everything stops," Aiko said.

Her father did not answer. They walked until the sky turned dark. Rain began without warning. They stood under a tree, but the rain grew stronger. Ren pointed to a small building beside the road, where a farmer had left a cart under a roof. They ran to it.

Aiko took the silk sample from her bag. The paper around it was wet. She opened the paper and checked the cloth. The green silk was dry because Yumi had wrapped it inside another piece of cloth. Aiko smiled at the thought of her mother's careful hands.

"The day I delivered the order," Ren said, "there was no rain. I am sure. I told Sato that he should cover the boxes inside his store because clouds were coming later. He laughed and said the goods would not stay there long."

Daichi turned toward him. "Did he say that before or after counting the rolls?"

"After. I remember because he was closing the back door."

They reached the Three Pines market late in the afternoon. The owner was a woman named Mrs. Mori. She had silver hair and sharp eyes. When Aiko explained why they had come, Mrs. Mori invited them into her shop.

"I remember the green silk," she said. "It was beautiful. I bought sixteen rolls. The seller's man said it came from a new workshop called Spring Willow."

"May we see one?" Daichi asked.

Mrs. Mori led them to a shelf. She opened a roll and placed it on the table. Aiko saw the colour first. Then she found the little blue mountain near the edge. She turned the cloth over. The final stitch pointed inward, just as her mother had shown her.

"This is ours," she whispered.

Mrs. Mori looked surprised. "Can you prove it?"

Aiko showed her own sample. Then she took the small needle from her bag and made the family mark on a piece of white cloth. She showed Mrs. Mori the hidden final stitch.

"The mark is unusual," Mrs. Mori said. "But I need more than a mark. I paid for these rolls. I must protect my customers too."

"Of course," Daichi answered. "We are not asking you to return them. We want to know who received the money."

Mrs. Mori went to a shelf behind her desk and took out a thin book. She found the page for the sale. There was a date, a price, and a name written at the bottom.

"This is the man who collected my payment," she said. "Sato. I remember him clearly. He wore a brown coat and carried a book with a red string."

Aiko felt the room become very quiet. Mrs. Mori copied the page for them and pressed her shop mark on the paper. "Take this. It may help. But do not use my name to make an angry story. Tell only what you know."

On the way home, Aiko held the paper carefully inside her coat. They had found sixteen rolls, but eight were still missing. They had found the name of the man who received money, but not the reason for his lie. The road was long, and night was coming. Still, for the first time in several days, Aiko felt that home was closer.

The next day, Aiko placed Mrs. Mori's copy on the workshop table. Daichi read it slowly. Ren stood beside him. Yumi put down her needle and came closer. There, under the price of sixteen rolls, was Sato's name.

"Why would he do this?" Daichi asked.

"Perhaps he wanted the money," said Ren.

"Or perhaps Kondo told him to sell the silk under a different name," Yumi answered. "We do not know yet."

Aiko looked at the figures again. "We need a second witness. The shop bought sixteen rolls. What happened to the other eight?"

Ren remembered a woman at the west gate who carried small packages for Kondo's store. Her name was Chiyo. He had seen her on the delivery day, walking with a basket. They went to ask her what she knew.

Chiyo was washing cups outside a tea shop. When Aiko described the green silk, she shook her head. "I do not know about the large boxes. But that day I carried eight smaller rolls to a private house. Sato gave them to me."

"Did he give you a paper?" Aiko asked.

"Yes. I keep papers until I am paid. He paid me the next week."

Chiyo went inside and returned with a little folded note. It said eight rolls of green silk and named the address. Below the words was Sato's mark. Aiko wanted to keep the paper, but Chiyo was afraid to give it away. She agreed to come to Kondo's store with them and show it herself.

That afternoon, Aiko, Daichi, Ren, and Chiyo arrived at Kondo's store. Sato saw them enter and stood up quickly. He did not smile.

"We have come with evidence," Daichi said.

Kondo looked from one face to another. "What evidence?"

Aiko showed him Mrs. Mori's copy. Then Chiyo placed her note on the desk. Kondo read both carefully. His face grew serious. He looked at Sato.

"You wrote that twelve rolls were missing and twelve were damaged," Kondo said. "But these papers show that twenty-four rolls went to other buyers. Explain this."

Sato's mouth opened, then closed. "I was following an old order. It was a mistake in the accounts."

"An old order?" Aiko asked. "The papers have the same date as our delivery."

Sato looked angry. "You are a child. You know nothing about the work of a large store."

"Then show us the page," Kondo said quietly. "The page in the red-string book."

Sato did not move. Kondo took a key from his pocket and opened the desk drawer. Inside was a book tied with a red string. He placed it on the table and turned the pages. On one page, the ink was darker than the lines around it. A number had been changed.

"Here is the delivery," Kondo said. "The first number looks like twenty-four. But someone wrote twelve over it."

Sato reached toward the book. "That paper is private."

Kondo moved it away. "It belongs to the business. Please sit down."

Sato sat. The sound of the market came through the open windows: footsteps, voices, a horse outside. For a long minute, Kondo read the book in silence.

"The money from the Three Pines sale is not here," he said at last. "Nor is the money from the private house."

Aiko looked at her father. They had proved that the rolls were not lost. Yet Kondo had not said he would pay. She waited, frightened that there might be another reason to lose the loom.

Kondo closed the book. "Tomorrow morning I will ask my partners to come here. Mrs. Mori and Chiyo may speak if they wish. Until then, your loom is safe. I will not touch it."

Daichi bowed his head. "Thank you."

Outside, Aiko took a deep breath. They had one day to prepare. The problem was no longer only about cloth. It was about words, records, and the people who had been afraid to speak.

CHAPTER 4

The Market of Voices

That night, Aiko could not sleep. She sat near the window and looked at the moon above the wet roofs. She thought of Emi at the house beyond the bridge. Emi had seen the silk being sold under a different name. She had told Aiko the truth even when she was afraid. But nobody had asked her to come to the meeting.

In the morning, Aiko found her mother working by the door. "I want to speak to Emi," she said.



"That is a long walk," Yumi replied. "And the meeting is at noon."

"I can go early. She should know that we found the rolls."

Yumi put a hand on Aiko's shoulder. "Go with Ren. And remember: do not ask her to risk her job just to help us. She has a family too."

Aiko and Ren left before breakfast. They walked quickly and reached the bridge while the shadows were still long. Emi was sweeping the path near the dealer's house. She looked surprised to see them.

"You came back," she said.

"We found sixteen rolls at the Three Pines shop," Aiko told her. "And we found papers for eight more. We are going to speak to Kondo's partners today."

Emi put down her broom. "Then you know the truth."

"We know where the silk went," Aiko said. "We do not know who decided to sell it in another name."

Emi looked toward the house. "I heard Sato speak to my master. He said Kondo was away that day and would not ask about the cloth until the end of the month. He told my master to pay him directly."

"Did you hear the price?" Ren asked.

"No. But I saw my master give him a small cloth bag. It made a sound like coins."

Aiko felt angry, but she tried to speak calmly. "Will you tell that story at the meeting? Only if you want to."

Emi looked down at her hands. "If I leave work, my master may be angry. I need this job. My mother is ill, and my younger sisters need food."

"Then do not come," Aiko said. "I wanted you to know that we are grateful. What you told us helped us find the silk."

Emi was silent for a moment. Then she reached into her coat and took out a small piece of paper. "When Sato came, he dropped this near the kitchen. I kept it because I thought it might be important."

On the paper were numbers and a short note: sixteen to Three Pines, eight to the house at the east wall. Beside the numbers was a small red mark. The writing looked like the writing in Sato's book.

"This could help," Aiko said.

"You may take it," Emi replied. "But please do not say that I stole it. I only picked it up from the ground."

"We will tell the truth," Aiko promised.

They began walking back to Kyoto. Near the bridge, Emi ran after them. "Wait," she called. "I have changed my mind. I want to speak for myself. My master often says that girls should be quiet. I am tired of being quiet when people are being hurt."

Aiko did not answer at once. She knew that Emi's choice could cost her much more than a few hours. "Are you sure?" she asked.

"Yes. But I want one thing. After the meeting, can you show me how to make the blue stitch?"

"Of course," Aiko said. "I can show you more than that."

They reached the store just before noon. Kondo's partners were already inside. Daichi stood near the door in his best jacket. Yumi was beside him, holding a roll of green silk. When Aiko entered with Emi, her mother smiled. Aiko felt afraid, but not alone.

Kondo had cleared a table in the middle of his store. Two partners sat beside him. One was an older man who knew the cloth trade well. The other was a woman who bought silk for several small shops. Sato sat alone near the wall. His red-string book lay closed in front of him.

Kondo spoke first. "There is a disagreement about twenty-four rolls of silk. I want the truth before I decide what to do. Please speak one at a time."

Daichi explained the agreement. He had made twenty-four rolls for four silver coins each. He had received twenty-four coins in advance. The last seventy-two coins were due after delivery. When he finished, Yumi opened her roll and showed the blue mark.

"I checked every piece," she said. "I made this sign at the edge of each roll. The last stitch turns inside the cloth. We do this so that our work can be known even after someone changes the paper around it."

Ren told them about the delivery cart. He remembered the sunny morning, the clean cover, and Sato counting all twenty-four rolls. Chiyo showed her paper for eight rolls. Mrs. Mori had sent a second copy of her account with a note saying that she would speak to anyone who needed her help.

Then Emi stood up. Her voice was soft at first. She described the dealer's house and the boxes of green silk. She said that she had heard Sato tell her master to pay him directly. She did not say she knew more than she had seen.

One of the partners asked, "Could you be wrong about the man?"

"I could be wrong about many things," Emi answered. "But I saw Sato's face. I heard his name. I remember the blue cover on the cart."

Aiko placed the small paper on the table. "Emi found this after he left. It shows sixteen rolls and eight rolls. Together they make twenty-four."

The older partner studied it. Then he opened the red-string book. "The handwriting appears to be Sato's. Here is the same shape in the number eight."

Kondo looked at Sato. "You may answer now."

Sato sat very still. At last he said, "I took the cloth. I sold it through the other dealer. I needed money because I owed money to a man in another town. I thought I could replace it before the accounts were checked."

"And you blamed my family," Daichi said.

Sato lowered his eyes. "Yes."

Kondo's face became dark with anger. "You used my name to take their loom."

For a moment, the room was full of voices. The partners asked questions. Daichi stood up. Ren spoke at the same time. Aiko felt the story slipping into a fight. She put both hands on the table.

"Please," she said. The room became quiet. "We came to protect our work. We do not want another family to lose everything. We want the seventy-two coins we earned, and we want the false claim removed."

Kondo looked at her for a long time. "You are right. I should have checked the records before sending such a letter. I trusted one book and did not listen to the people who had done the work."

He wrote a new paper. It said that Daichi's family had delivered twenty-four good rolls and owed nothing. He signed it. Both partners signed as witnesses. Then he counted seventy-two silver coins onto the table.

"This is the money you are owed," he said. "I will also pay the cost of your journey. It was my store's mistake."

Daichi did not smile at once. He looked at the coins and then at Sato. "I hope you find a way to repay what you took."

The partners agreed that Sato could no longer keep the shop accounts. He would have to repay the missing money through proper work, and Kondo would speak to the local official about the matter. Nobody in the room could decide his whole future that day.

Outside, the market was busy as ever. But for Aiko, the noise was different. Every call and every footstep sounded like a person with a story. She knew now that a market was not only a place where things were sold. It was also a place where people's words could change what was fair.

CHAPTER 5

The Road Home

Three days later, the workshop sounded like a happy home again. The large loom stood beside the window. Yumi moved the shuttle through the threads, and Daichi checked a new order at the table. Aiko had put their agreement with Kondo inside the old wooden chest. The chest now held a second book too: a small record of every order and every delivery.

"Name of buyer," Aiko read aloud. "Number of rolls. Date. Price. Name of driver. Signature of the person who receives them."



Ren laughed. "That is a lot of writing for one cart."

"Then bring a larger bag for the papers," Aiko replied.

They both laughed. But Aiko was serious. She had learned that careful work did not end when the silk left the loom. It continued along the road, through shops, and into other hands.

Kondo visited the workshop that week. He did not come with guards or angry letters. He came alone, carrying a small wooden box. Inside were new tools for repairing the looms. He placed the box on the table.

"I cannot change what happened," he told Daichi. "But I can be more careful in the future. I hope you will sell to me again one day."

Daichi thanked him for the tools. "Perhaps," he said. "But next time we will make the agreement together, and both sides will keep a copy."

"That is fair," Kondo answered.

When Kondo left, Aiko took the old map from the chest. She spread it beside the new record book. The road to the Three Pines market still crossed the paper like a narrow line of ink.

"I want to visit Mrs. Mori again," she said. "Not because something is wrong. I want to ask if she will buy from us directly. There are other shops along the road too."

Yumi looked interested. "We would have to make smaller orders for different customers."

"Yes," Aiko said. "And we would have to travel more. But if one buyer cannot pay, the whole workshop will not be in danger."

Daichi thought for a moment. "Your grandfather would like that idea. He always loved the road."

The next Saturday, Aiko travelled west with Ren and Emi. Emi no longer worked at the dealer's house. After the meeting, the dealer had told her not to return. Aiko's family invited her to learn weaving for a small wage. She accepted at once. Now she carried a little sewing bag and smiled whenever she touched the blue thread inside.

At the Three Pines market, Mrs. Mori welcomed them. She listened to Aiko's idea and ordered four rolls of green silk. A second shopkeeper ordered two rolls of blue cloth. An old woman who sold wedding

clothes asked to see samples in the summer. Aiko wrote down every name and number.

After the market, they sat on a low wall beside the road. The hills were green, and the sky was clear. Ren took out the last rice cake from his bag and broke it into three pieces.

"What will you call your new business?" he asked.

"We already have a name," Aiko said. "Our family name is enough."

"Then what is the road for?" asked Emi.

Aiko looked at the path leading east. She remembered her grandfather's map, her mother's blue stitches, and the long walk in the rain. "The road brings our cloth to other people," she said. "But it also brings us knowledge. Friends. Courage."

"And sometimes wet shoes," Ren added.

They laughed and began the walk home. When Kyoto came into view, evening light shone on the roofs. Aiko could almost hear the looms before she reached the workshop. She understood something she had not known before: home was not only a building with wooden walls. It was a place people protected together, through honest work and brave words.

At the door, Yumi waited with a lamp. Aiko showed her the new orders. Emi held up her first small piece of green silk. Ren put the bags on the floor. Daichi brought tea for everyone. They sat around the table and made plans for the next day.

Before bed, Aiko opened the old chest one more time. She placed the map beside the new record book. Across the faded paper, her grandfather's words were still easy to read: The road that brings silk home.

Aiko closed the chest. Tomorrow there would be more work, more questions, and perhaps more difficult days. But there would also be a road. And now she knew how to follow it.

Glossary

40 useful words from the story · in alphabetical order

Read each word, its meaning, and the short example.

Word	Meaning	Example
advance	money paid before work is finished	Kondo paid an advance before the cloth was ready.
agreement	a plan or promise accepted by two or more people	The agreement named the delivery date.
buyer	a person who pays for something	The buyer wanted twenty-four rolls of silk.
cart	a vehicle with wheels used to carry goods	Ren drove the cart through the city.
clerk	a person who writes records for a business	The clerk wrote numbers in a large book.
cloth	material made from thread	Yumi checked every piece of cloth.
coin	a small round piece of money	A silver coin fell on the table.
condition	the state of something, for example good or bad	The silk arrived in good condition.
courage	the ability to do something although you are afraid	Emi showed courage when she spoke.
customer	a person who buys things from a shop	The workshop welcomed another customer.
damaged	broken or not in good condition	Sato said the cloth was damaged.
dealer	a person who buys and sells goods	The dealer sold silk to other shops.
debt	money that one person must pay back	Daichi worried about the family debt.
delivery	the act of bringing goods to a person or place	The delivery left Kyoto in the morning.
evidence	information or objects that help show what is true	The receipts became important evidence.

Word	Meaning	Example
fair	right and reasonable to everyone	Aiko wanted a fair answer.
goods	things made or sold by a business	They carried the goods across the bridge.
honest	telling the truth and not cheating	Ren gave an honest answer.
ink	coloured liquid used for writing	Daichi put fresh ink on his pen.
journey	a trip from one place to another	The long journey began before sunrise.
lamp	an object that gives light	A small lamp lit the room.
loom	a machine or wooden frame for making cloth	The family used the old loom every day.
market	a place where people buy and sell things	They met Mrs. Mori at the market.
merchant	a person who buys and sells goods	The merchant spoke to Daichi.
order	a request to make or buy something	The order included twenty-four rolls.
parcel	something wrapped and sent to a person	A small parcel arrived at the workshop.
partner	a person who shares work or business with another	A good partner helps when work is difficult.
pattern	a repeated design of lines, shapes, or colours	The silk had a beautiful pattern.
protect	to keep someone or something safe	Aiko wanted to protect the workshop.
receipt	a piece of paper showing that goods or money were received	A receipt showed who received the rolls.
record	information written and kept for later	Sato changed the record in the book.
repay	to give back money you owe	They had to repay the advance.
risk	the possibility that something bad may happen	Emi took a risk to tell the truth.

Word	Meaning	Example
roll	a long piece of material that is wrapped around itself	One roll of silk had a blue mark.
sample	a small piece used to show what something is like	Yumi carried a small sample of green silk.
silk	soft, fine cloth made from special natural thread	The family made silk in Kyoto.
stitch	one movement of a needle and thread through cloth	Yumi made a blue stitch on each roll.
thread	a thin piece of material used to sew or weave	Aiko held a blue thread in her hand.
truth	what really happened or what is real	They worked together to find the truth.
witness	a person who sees something happen	A witness saw the missing cart.

Reading Comprehension

Read the full story first. Choose A, B, or C.

1. Aiko lives in ...

a) Tokyo b) Kyoto c) Osaka

2. Her family makes ...

a) silk b) shoes c) paper

3. The family delivery contained ...

a) 12 rolls b) 16 rolls c) 24 rolls

4. The family mark is made with ...

a) blue stitches b) red ink c) a wooden stamp

5. Kondo's clerk is named ...

a) Ren b) Sato c) Ito

6. Ren works as a ...

a) delivery driver b) doctor c) teacher

7. Emi is afraid of losing her ...

a) umbrella b) map c) job

8. Mr. Ito delivered some silk to ...

a) Three Pines b) the coast c) Tokyo

9. Mrs. Mori bought ...

a) 8 rolls b) 16 rolls c) 24 rolls

10. Chiyo carried ...

a) 8 rolls b) 12 rolls c) 16 rolls

11. The special last stitch points ...

a) up b) out c) inward

12. Kondo promised to wait before taking ...

a) their house b) their loom c) their cart

13. Aiko's family is owed another ...

a) 72 coins b) 24 coins c) 16 coins

14. Sato hid the sale in his ...

a) bag b) account book c) coat

15. Emi agrees to ...

a) speak at the meeting b) leave Kyoto forever c) hide the truth

Short Answer Questions

Write one or two sentences for each question.

Chapter 1 · The Blue Thread

What work does Aiko's family do?

What is the little blue mark on the silk?

How many rolls did the family send to Kondo?

Why could the family lose its large loom?

What does Ren remember about the delivery?

What does Aiko find in her grandfather's chest?

Chapter 2 · The Girl at the Gate

Who tells Aiko about the cart with the blue cover?

Why is Emi afraid to speak freely?

What does Emi remember about the green silk?

Why does Aiko refuse to ask Emi to open the locked room?

Who is Mr. Ito, and what does he tell the young people?

What name was written on the new paper around the rolls?

Chapter 3 · A Journey in the Rain

Why do Aiko, Ren, and Daichi travel to the Three Pines market?

What protects the family silk sample during the rain?

How many rolls did Mrs. Mori buy?

What special detail is in the final blue stitch?

Whose name appears on Mrs. Mori’s sale record?

What does Chiyo’s paper show?

Chapter 4 · The Market of Voices

What does Kondo promise before the meeting?

Why does Aiko go to see Emi again?

What evidence do the different witnesses bring?

What does Sato finally admit?

How much more money does Kondo pay the family?

Why does Aiko ask everyone to stop arguing?

Chapter 5 · The Road Home

What new information does Aiko write down for each order?

How does Kondo try to say sorry?

Why does Aiko want to sell to several shops?

What new work does Emi begin?

What orders does Aiko receive at the Three Pines market?

What does Aiko learn about the meaning of home?

Language Practice

A · Past and Present

Complete the sentences with the correct form of the verb.

1. Aiko ___ (work) at a loom every morning.

2. Ren ___ (carry) the rolls to Kondo's store yesterday.

3. Kondo ___ (write) an angry letter to the family.

4. The family ___ (not / lose) hope.

5. ___ Aiko ___ (find) the map in the chest?

6. They ___ (walk) west through the rain.

7. Mrs. Mori ___ (buy) sixteen rolls.

8. Emi ___ (be) brave at the meeting.

B · Linking Ideas

Choose the correct word or phrase in brackets.

1. ___ it was raining, the group walked on. (Although / Because)

2. They waited inside ___ the heavy rain. (because of / so)

3. Aiko went to the market ___ she needed evidence. (because / but)

4. She was worried, ___ she kept asking questions. (but / because)

5. ___ Sato spoke, everyone became quiet. (When / But)

6. Kondo checked the records ___ he made a decision. (before / because)

7. Aiko wanted to help Emi ___ she offered her work. (so / although)

8. They walked home ___ the meeting ended. (after / but)

C · Advice, Ability, and Rules

Choose the correct modal verb.

1. You ___ check a receipt before you leave. (should / cannot)

2. We ___ tell the truth even when we are afraid. (must / might not)

3. Emi ___ open the locked room without permission. (must not / should)

4. Ren ___ remember the weather on that day. (can / must not)

5. We ___ ask other people for help when we need it. (can / never)

6. You ___ accuse a person without evidence. (should not / should)

Think · Speak · Write

Discuss the questions with a partner. Then write your ideas in English.

1. Why is the blue mark important to the family?

2. Was Aiko right to look for the missing silk? Explain.

3. Which person took the greatest risk to tell the truth?

4. Why is a written receipt useful for both a buyer and a seller?

5. Do you think Kondo treated the family fairly at the end?

6. What does the sentence “the road brings silk home” mean to you?

Writing Task

Write 100–120 words about the following situation:

You work in a small shop. One day, a customer says an order did not arrive. Describe what you do, who helps you, and how you solve the problem.

Use past simple verbs, because / but / so, and at least four words from the glossary.

Title: _____

Final Test

A · True or False? (10 points)

1. The story takes place in Kyoto in 1871. (T / F)

2. Aiko's mother makes the family blue mark. (T / F)

3. Kondo receives only one roll of silk. (T / F)

4. Ren remembers a dry delivery day. (T / F)

5. Emi is the owner of the cloth dealer's house. (T / F)

6. Mr. Ito carried sixteen rolls to the Three Pines market. (T / F)

7. Mrs. Mori refuses to show any records. (T / F)

8. Chiyo carried eight smaller rolls for Sato. (T / F)

9. Sato admits that he sold the silk without permission. (T / F)

10. Aiko decides to work with only one buyer in future. (T / F)

B · Choose the Best Answer (20 points)

1. Aiko lives in ...

a) Tokyo b) Kyoto c) Osaka

2. Her family makes ...

a) silk b) shoes c) paper

3. The family delivery contained ...

a) 12 rolls b) 16 rolls c) 24 rolls

4. The family mark is made with ...

a) blue stitches b) red ink c) a wooden stamp

5. Kondo's clerk is named ...

a) Ren b) Sato c) Ito

6. Ren works as a ...

a) delivery driver b) doctor c) teacher

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a) umbrella b) map c) job

8. Mr. Ito delivered some silk to ...

a) Three Pines b) the coast c) Tokyo

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13. Aiko's family is owed another ...

a) 72 coins b) 24 coins c) 16 coins

14. Sato hid the sale in his ...

a) bag b) account book c) coat

15. Emi agrees to ...

a) speak at the meeting b) leave Kyoto forever c) hide the truth

16. Kondo pays the money because …

a) the silk is found and the facts are clear b) Aiko shouts loudly c) he is afraid of rain

17. Aiko keeps new records to …

a) decorate the shop b) protect future orders c) teach numbers

18. Emi later learns …

a) weaving b) farming c) painting

19. The shop called Three Pines orders …

a) four green rolls b) six green rolls c) eight green rolls

20. The story is mainly about …

a) a sports race b) truth and family courage c) a sea trip

C · Short Response (10 points)

In 40–60 words, explain how Aiko and her friends proved that the family had delivered the silk.

Total possible score: 40 points.

Answer Key

Check your answers after you finish the activities.

Reading Comprehension · Choose A, B, or C

1. b, 2. a, 3. c, 4. a, 5. b, 6. a, 7. c, 8. a, 9. b, 10. a, 11. c, 12. b, 13. a, 14. b, 15. a

Short Answers · Sample Answers

Chapter 1 · The Blue Thread

1. They make and sell silk cloth.

2. Three blue stitches shaped like a mountain above water.

3. Twenty-four rolls.

4. Kondo claimed the delivery was lost or damaged and wanted his advance money back.

5. Sato counted all twenty-four rolls at the store.

6. An old map of the roads west of Kyoto.

Chapter 2 · The Girl at the Gate

1. A woman who sells food and tea near the western gate.

2. She may lose her job if her master hears her.

3. The rolls were green and had Aiko's family blue mark.

4. Emi could lose the money her family needs.

5. A delivery driver who carried sixteen rolls to another market.

6. Spring Willow.

Chapter 3 · A Journey in the Rain

1. To find the missing silk and ask who received the money.

2. Yumi wrapped it inside an extra piece of cloth.

3. Sixteen rolls.

4. The last stitch points inward, inside the cloth.

5. Sato.

6. She carried eight rolls to a private house for Sato.

Chapter 4 · The Market of Voices

1. He will not take their loom until he hears the facts.

2. To thank her and tell her they have found more evidence.

3. A delivery account, a note, blue stitches, witnesses, and Sato's book.

4. He sold the cloth through another dealer, took the money, and blamed the family.

5. Seventy-two silver coins.

6. She wants a fair decision based on evidence, not a fight.

Chapter 5 · The Road Home

1. Buyer, number of rolls, date, price, driver, and receiver's signature.

2. He brings tools and admits his store made a mistake.

3. If one customer cannot pay, the workshop can still sell to others.

4. She becomes a paid apprentice in the workshop.

5. Four green rolls for Mrs. Mori and two blue rolls for another shop.

6. Home is a place people protect together through honest work, friendship, and courage.

Language Practice

A · 1. works; 2. carried; 3. wrote; 4. did not lose; 5. Did / find; 6. walked; 7. bought; 8. was

B · 1. Although; 2. because of; 3. because; 4. but; 5. When; 6. before; 7. so; 8. after

C · 1. should; 2. must; 3. must not; 4. can; 5. can; 6. should not

Final Test

A · True / False: 1. T, 2. T, 3. F, 4. T, 5. F, 6. T, 7. F, 8. T, 9. T, 10. F

B · Multiple Choice: 1. b, 2. a, 3. c, 4. a, 5. b, 6. a, 7. c, 8. a, 9. b, 10. a, 11. c, 12. b, 13. a, 14. b, 15. a, 16. a, 17. b, 18. a, 19. a, 20. b

C · Model answer: Aiko found the family's blue mark on the cloth. Mrs. Mori had records for sixteen rolls, and Chiyo had a note about eight more. The witnesses helped the family show that all twenty-four rolls had arrived.

Open discussion and writing tasks can have more than one correct response.

WorldVoice Library

The Silk Road Home

This graded reader includes:

- A touching historical story
- Five illustrated chapters
- A glossary of key vocabulary (40 words)
- Comprehension and discussion questions
- A writing task

English Level
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Elementary



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